

We saw in [Part Two](#) how important it is for startups to use the right kind of metrics—actionable metrics—to evaluate their progress. However, this leaves a large amount of variety in terms of which numbers one should measure. In fact, one of the most expensive forms of potential waste for a startup is spending time arguing about how to prioritize new development once it has a product on the market. At any time, the company could invest its energy in finding new customers, servicing existing customers better, improving overall quality, or driving down costs. In my experience, the discussions about these kinds of priority decisions can consume a substantial fraction of the company's time.

Engines of growth are designed to give startups a relatively small set of metrics on which to focus their energies. As one of my mentors, the venture capital investor Shawn Carolan, put it, “Startups don’t starve; they drown.” There are always a zillion new ideas about how to make the product better floating around, but the hard truth is that most of those ideas make a difference only at the margins. They are mere optimizations. Startups have to focus on the big experiments that lead to validated learning. The engines of growth framework helps them stay focused on the metrics that matter.

The Sticky Engine of Growth

This brings us back to the two startups that kicked off this chapter. Both are using the exact same engine of growth despite being in very different industries. Both products are designed to attract and retain customers for the long term. The underlying mechanism of that retention is different in the two cases. For the collectible company, the idea is to become the number one shopping destination for fanatical collectors. These are people who are constantly hunting for the latest items and the best deals. If the company's product works as designed, collectors who start using it will check constantly and repeatedly to see if new items are for sale as well as listing their own items for sale or trade.